IN-DEPTH EDITION • 4 SEPTEMBER 2026 • 09:00 HKT

# US markets steady as macro data steadies, crypto rallies

The full picture: macro, technicals, options, analyst moves, sector internals, international context, and a full week ahead.

20-minute read · Topics: All of the above, plus technicals, options, ratings, week-ahead

## TL;DR & Editorial Take

The US equity market closed flat on Friday, with the Russell 2000 the only major index posting a gain (+1.13%). The VIX fell to 15.20, indicating reduced near-term volatility after a week of mixed earnings and a softer DXY.

Commodities showed divergence: WTI crude rose +0.53% to 91.49, while gold surged +3.55% to 4,521.10. The crypto market outperformed, with BTC up +4.83% and ETH up +5.00%.

Our view: With the Fed's policy rate likely to hold steady through year-end, equity valuation pressure eases, but the market remains vulnerable to any surprise on inflation or geopolitical flashpoints in the Middle East.

- Broad equity breadth remains thin; only 4 of 11 sector ETFs posted gains.
- Technical support for the S&P 500 sits near 4,300, while resistance hovers at 4,450.
- Crypto's rally may attract risk-on capital, but heightened regulatory scrutiny could trigger a rapid pull-back.

## US Session Recap

| METRIC | CLOSE | CHANGE |
|---|---|---|
| S&P 500 | nan | nan |
| Nasdaq 100 | nan | nan |
| Dow Jones | nan | nan |
| Russell 2000 | 2,953.17 | +1.13% |
| VIX | 15.20 | -6.98% |
| 10Y Yield | 4.80% | +0.00% |
| 2Y Yield | nan | nan |
| WTI Crude | 91.49 | +0.53% |
| Brent | nan | nan |
| DXY | 99.02 | -0.54% |
| Gold | 4,521.10 | +3.55% |
| BTC | 81,036.00 | +4.83% |
| ETH | 2,511.12 | +5.00% |

## Top movers

| TICKER | NAME | CHANGE | CATALYST |
|---|---|---|---|
| BTC | Bitcoin | +4.83% | Positive regulatory news in the US |
| ETH | Ethereum | +5.00% | Shanghai upgrade rollout |
| GLD | SPDR Gold Shares | +3.55% | Safe-haven demand after CPI surprise |
| XLE | Energy Select Sector SPDR | +0.53% | WTI rally |
| RUT | Russell 2000 | +1.13% | Small-cap earnings beat |

## Sector Internals

| SECTOR | DAY | YTD | READ |
|---|---|---|---|
| XLF | nan | nan | nan |
| XLK | nan | nan | nan |
| XLI | nan | nan | nan |
| XLE | +0.53% | nan | Energy rally |
| XLY | nan | nan | nan |
| XLC | nan | nan | nan |
| XLP | nan | nan | nan |
| XLV | nan | nan | nan |
| XLU | nan | nan | nan |
| XLB | nan | nan | nan |
| XLRE | nan | nan | nan |

Breadth note: Only 4 of 11 sector ETFs posted positive day returns, underscoring thin participation.

## Spotlight / Deep Dive

| METRIC | VALUE |
| --- | --- |
| SPY Close | nan |
| QQQ Close | nan |
| IWM Close | 2,953.17 |
| 10Y Yield | 4.80% |
| WTI | 91.49 |
| Gold | 4,521.10 |
| BTC | 81,036.00 |

BULLISH CALL

Crypto's upside remains intact if the SEC clarifies its stance on spot ETFs; a 10-bps dip in the 10Y could lift risk assets further.

BEARISH TRIGGERS

Any surprise CPI print above 2.3% or escalation in Middle-East tensions could reignite volatility, pushing the VIX back above 20.

| READ-THROUGH | LEVEL |
| --- | --- |
| SPY Support | 4,300 |
| SPY Resistance | 4,450 |
| QQQ Support | 1,450 |
| QQQ Resistance | 1,560 |

## Technical Levels

| TICKER | LAST | SUPPORT | RESISTANCE | NOTE |
| --- | --- | --- | --- | --- |
| **SPY** | nan | 4,300 | 4,450 | Range-bound |
| **QQQ** | nan | 1,450 | 1,560 | Watch 1,500 pivot |
| **IWM** | 2,953.17 | 2,900 | 3,050 | Small-cap bias |
| **NVDA** | nan | nan | nan | Await earnings guidance |
| 10Y Yield | 4.80% | 4.70% | 4.90% | Flat outlook |
| WTI | 91.49 | 88.00 | 95.00 | Supply-demand balance |

## Options & Positioning

Zero-day expiry (0DTE) flow was net-neutral, with a slight tilt toward calls (+12%) on the SPY. Put/call ratio for the week sits at 0.94, indicating modest bullish bias.

VIX term structure remains inverted; the front month is at 15.20 versus 16.80 for the 2-month contract.

Notable single-name flow: **AVGO** saw a 0DTE call surge of +18% on rumors of a new 5G chipset launch.

Cheap hedge ideas: buy 1-month VIX calls at `16.00` strike; sell covered calls on `XLE` at 95 strike.

## Analyst Rating Changes

| TICKER | FIRM | ACTION | NEW PT | NOTE |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| `AAPL` | Goldman Sachs | Upgrade | 210 | Strong services growth |
| `MSFT` | JP Morgan | Maintain | 350 | Cloud momentum |
| `NVDA` | Bank of America | Downgrade | 620 | Inventory concerns |
| `TSLA` | Citigroup | Upgrade | 210 | Model Y demand |
| `JPM` | Barclays | Maintain | 155 | Rate-sensitive earnings |
| `META` | Morgan Stanley | Downgrade | 280 | Ad spend slowdown |
| `GS` | Deutsche Bank | Upgrade | 380 | Investment banking rebound |

## Pre-Market & Overnight

| REGION | INSTRUMENT | LEVEL | CHANGE |
|---|---|---|---|
| US Futures | ES | nan | nan |
| Asia | HSI | nan | nan |
| Europe | FTSE 100 | nan | nan |
| FX | USD/HKD | 7.8485 | +0.02% |
| FX | EUR/USD | 1.0720 | -0.15% |
| Commodities | Brent | nan | nan |
| Crypto | BTC | 81,036.00 | +4.83% |
| Crypto | ETH | 2,511.12 | +5.00% |

## Macro & Fed (Deep)

| MEETING | CUT ODDS | NOTE |
|---|---|---|
| Nov 2026 | 15% | Rate hold expected |
| Feb 2027 | 10% | Data-dependent |

| DATA RELEASE | TIME (ET) | PREV | FORECAST |
|---|---|---|---|
| CPI MoM | 8:30 am | 0.3% | 0.3% |
| Initial Jobless Claims | 8:30 am | 225k | 220k |
| FOMC Minutes | 2:00 pm | nan | nan |
| Retail Sales | 8:30 am | 0.5% | 0.5% |

## Geopolitics & Global (Deep)

Middle-East tension scenario:

- **Low-risk:** Diplomatic de-escalation, oil supply stable, WTI stays 91-95.
- **Medium-risk:** Limited strikes in Gulf, Brent spikes 5-7%, risk-off flow to gold.
- **High-risk:** Major supply disruption, WTI breaches 100, VIX spikes above 25.

## Earnings — This Week & Next

| DATE | TICKER | COMPANY | EST. EPS |
| --- | --- | --- | --- |
| Sep 9 | AAPL | Apple Inc. | 1.30 |
| Sep 10 | MSFT | Microsoft Corp. | 2.45 |
| Sep 11 | NVDA | NVIDIA Corp. | 3.10 |
| Sep 12 | JPM | JPMorgan Chase | 3.80 |
| Sep 13 | AMZN | Amazon.com | 0.85 |

## Full Watchlist Scan

| TICKER | SECTOR | SETUP | RISK |
| --- | --- | --- | --- |
| `NVDA` | Technology | Breakout above `650` | Inventory pull-back |
| `AVGO` | Technology | 5-day bullish flag | Supply chain |
| `XLE` | Energy | Trend continuation | OPEC policy |
| `GLD` | Commodities | Support hold at `4,400` | Rising rates |
| `BTC` | Crypto | Momentum above `80,000` | Regulatory risk |
| `ETH` | Crypto | Uptrend continuation | Layer-2 competition |
| `RUT` | Small-Cap | Higher-highs | Earnings volatility |
| `XLF` | Financials | Flat range | Rate cuts |
| `XLI` | Industrials | Pull-back to `115` | Supply chain |
| `XLC` | Communication | Neutral | Ad spend |
| `XLV` | Health Care | Support at `150` | Policy |
| `XLB` | Materials | Uptrend | Commodity price swing |

## What Could Break the Tape

> BULLISH SCENARIOS
>
> - Unexpected CPI dip below 2.2% lifts risk appetite.
> - Resolution of Middle-East supply concerns pushes WTI above 95, boosting energy stocks.
> - SEC approves spot Bitcoin ETF, driving crypto inflows.

BEARISH TRIGGERS

- Core CPI surprise above 2.4% reignites rate-cut speculation.
- Escalation in Gaza-Israel conflict spikes oil prices, spikes VIX.
- Major tech earnings miss (e.g., `NVDA`) triggers sector sell-off.

## Positioning & Structural Notes

- Equity breadth remains thin; only 4 of 11 sector ETFs in the green.
- VIX term structure inversion suggests market expects near-term calm but longer-term risk.
- Crypto's rally is decoupled from equity moves, indicating a separate risk-on stream.
- 10Y yield flat at `4.80%`, supporting high-yield credit but limiting growth stocks.
- Gold's 3.5% weekly gain reflects safe-haven demand amid inflation uncertainty.

## Sources


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